

The Body of the Speech

The first step in developing a strong sense of speech organization is to gain command of the three basic parts—introduction, body, and conclusion—and the strategic role of each. We begin with the body, the longest and most important part.

The process of organizing the body of a speech begins when you determine the main points.

MAIN POINTS

The main points form the skeleton of the body of the speech. You should select them carefully, phrase them precisely, and arrange them strategically.

How do you choose your main points? Sometimes they will be evident from your specific purpose statement. Suppose your specific purpose is “To inform my audience about the history, technology, and benefits of driverless cars.” Obviously, your speech will have three main points:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience about the history, technology, and benefits of driverless cars.

Central Idea: Once a dream of futurists, driverless cars are now a reality, developed through recent technological advancements and capable of saving lives and reducing road congestion.

Main Points: I. Driverless cars have long been the subject of science fiction writers and popular imagination.

II. Driverless cars today operate through a combination of network connectivity, intelligent computer processing, and sensors that constantly scan the car’s surroundings.

III. Driverless cars have the potential to save lives and to reduce congestion on roadways.

Even if your main points are not stated expressly in your specific purpose, they may be easy to project from it. Let’s say your specific purpose is “To inform my audience of the basic steps in making stained-glass windows.” You know each of your main points will correspond to a step in the windowmaking process. They might look like this in outline form:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience of the basic steps in making stained glass windows.

Central Idea: There are four steps in making stained-glass windows.

Main Points: I. The first step is designing the window.

II. The second step is cutting the glass to fit the design.

III. The third step is painting the glass.

IV. The fourth step is assembling the window.

NUMBER OF MAIN POINTS

You will not have time in your classroom speeches to develop more than four or five main

points, and the audience will also have trouble sorting them out. If you find that you have too many, you may condense them into categories. Here is a set of main points for a speech about yoga:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience about the practice of yoga.

Central Idea: Yoga is an ancient practice that involves the whole body.

Main Points: I. Yoga breathing starts with deep inhalation.

II. Yoga breathing requires slow exhalation.

III. Yoga breathing includes prolonged pauses.

IV. Yoga breathing provides many benefits.

V. Yoga postures involve all parts of the body.

VI. Yoga postures increase flexibility.

VII. Yoga postures strengthen muscle tone.

VIII. Yoga postures demand precise movements.

You have eight main points—which is too many. But they fall into two broad categories: yoga breathing and yoga postures. You might, therefore, restate your main points this way:

Main Points: I. One part of practicing yoga involves proper breathing.

II. Another part of yoga involves body postures.

STRATEGIC ORDER OF MAIN POINTS

Once you establish your main points, you need to decide the order in which you will present them. The most effective order depends on three things—your topic, your purpose, and your audience. Here we look briefly at the five basic patterns of organization used most often by public speakers.

Chronological Order

Speeches arranged chronologically follow a time pattern. They may narrate a series of events in the sequence in which they happened. For example:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience how the Great Wall of China was built.

Central Idea: The Great Wall of China was built in three major stages.

Main Points: I. Building of the Great Wall began during the Qin dynasty of 221–206 B.C.

II. New sections of the Great Wall were added during the Han dynasty of 206 B.C.–220 A.D.

III. The Great Wall was completed during the Ming dynasty of 1368–1644.

Chronological order is also used in speeches explaining a process or demonstrating how to do something. For example:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience of the steps in laser-assisted corrective eye surgery.

Central Idea: There are three main steps in laser-assisted corrective eye surgery.

Main Points: I. First, a thin layer is sliced off the surface of the eye to expose the cornea.

II. Second, an ultraviolet laser is used to reshape the cornea.

III. Third, the thin layer sliced off at the beginning of the surgery is reattached to the eye.

As this outline shows, chronological order is especially useful for informative speeches.

Spatial Order

Speeches arranged in spatial order follow a directional pattern. That is, the main points proceed from top to bottom, left to right, front to back, inside to outside, east to west, or some other route. For example:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience about the structure of a hurricane.

Central Idea: A hurricane is made up of three parts going from inside to outside.

Main Points: I. At the center of a hurricane is the calm, cloud-free eye.

II. Surrounding the eye is the eyewall, a dense ring of clouds that produces the most intense wind and rainfall.

III. Rotating around the eyewall are large bands of clouds and precipitation called spiral rain bands.

Or:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience about the three major regions in Italy.

Central Idea: Northern, central, and southern Italy have their own identities and attractions.

Main Points: I. Northern Italy is home to Venice and its world-famous canals.

II. Central Italy is home to Rome and its historical treasures.

III. Southern Italy is home to Sicily and its culinary traditions.

Spatial order, like chronological order, is used most often in informative speeches.

Causal Order

Speeches arranged in causal order organize main points so as to show a cause-effect relationship. Depending on your topic, you can devote your first main point to the causes and the second to the effects, or vice versa.

Suppose your specific purpose is “To persuade my audience that a growing shortage of air-traffic controllers is a serious problem for U.S. aviation.” Then you would begin with the causes of the shortage and work toward its effects:

Specific Purpose: To persuade my audience that a growing shortage of qualified air-traffic controllers is a serious problem for U.S. aviation.

Central Idea: The growing shortage of certified air-traffic controllers threatens the safety of air travel.

Main Points: I. The U.S. aviation system faces a growing shortage of qualified air-traffic controllers.

II. If this shortage continues, it will create serious problems for airline safety.

If the effects have already occurred, you may want to reverse the order and talk first about the effects and then about their causes:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience about possible causes for the collapse of the Ancient Pueblo civilization.

Central Idea: The causes for the collapse of the Ancient Pueblo civilization have not yet been fully explained.

Main Points: I. Ancient Pueblo civilization flourished for over a thousand years until 1200 A.D., when it mysteriously began to disintegrate.

II. Scholars have advanced three major explanations for the causes of this disintegration.

Because of its versatility, causal order can be used for both persuasive speeches and informative speeches.

Problem-Solution Order

Speeches arranged in problem-solution order are divided into two main parts. The first shows the existence and seriousness of a problem. The second presents a workable solution to the problem. For example:

Specific Purpose: To persuade my audience that action is needed to combat the abuses of puppy mills.

Central Idea: Puppy mills are a serious problem that can be solved by a combination of legislation and individual initiative.

Main Points: I. Puppy mills are a serious problem across the United States.

II. Solving the problem requires legislation and individual initiative.

As the example indicates, problem-solution order is most appropriate for persuasive speeches.

Topical Order

Topical order results when you divide the speech topic into subtopics, each of which becomes a main point in the speech.

Let's say your topic is Josephine Baker, an African-American entertainer and social activist in the middle of the 20th century. You could organize your speech chronologically—by discussing Baker's exploits during each decade of her career. On the other hand, you could arrange the speech topically—by dividing Baker's accomplishments into categories. Then your central idea and main points might be:

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience about the achievements of Josephine Baker.

Central Idea: Josephine Baker was a multitalented figure in the fight for racial justice.

Main Points: I. As an entertainer, Baker captivated audiences in Europe and America.

II. As a spy, Baker gathered information on Nazi activities in France during World War II.

III. As a civil rights activist, Baker worked for racial equality on a variety of fronts.

Notice how the main points subdivide the speech topic logically and consistently. Each main point isolates one aspect of Baker's achievements.

Vocabulary

序号	单词	中文释义	例句
1	skeleton (n.)	框架, 骨架	The committee first drafted the skeleton of the policy, which would later be fleshed out with specific clauses. (委员会首先起草了政策的 框架 , 后续将用具体条款和细节来充实它。)
2	phrase (v.)	用语言表达, 措辞	The diplomat carefully phrased her response to avoid escalating the tensions. (这位外交官谨慎地 措辞 , 以避免紧张局势升级。)
3	congestion (n.)	拥堵	Urban planners are investing in public transport to alleviate traffic congestion . (城市规划者正在投资公共交通以缓解交通 拥堵 。)
4	science fiction (n.)	科幻小说	Many technologies once depicted only in science fiction have now become reality. (许多曾仅存在于 科幻小说 中的技术如今已成为现实。)
5	connectivity (n.)	连接, 连通性	The development of 5G promises to enhance global connectivity and enable the Internet of Things. (5G 的发展有望增强全球 连通性 , 并实现物联网。)
6	sensor (n.)	传感器	The smart factory is equipped with thousands of sensors that monitor the production line in real time. (这座智能工厂配备了数千个 传感器 , 用于实时监控生产线。)
7	expressly (adv.)	明确地	The company's mission statement expressly forbids the use of conflict minerals in its supply chain. (公司的使命宣言 明确禁止 在其供应链中使用冲突矿产。)
8	project from (v.)	从...中推断出, 从...中规划出	Analysts could project from the economic data that a period of inflation was likely. (分析师可以从经济数据中 推断出 , 一段通胀期很可能即将到来。)
9	stained (adj.)	染色的 (文中“stained-glass”指彩色玻璃)	The medieval cathedral is renowned for its magnificent stained -glass windows. (这座中世纪大教堂以其宏伟的 彩色玻璃窗 而闻名。)
10	correspond to (v.)	对应于, 与...一致	The peaks on the graph correspond to periods of highest user activity. (图上的峰值 对应于 用户活动最频繁的时段。)
11	assemble (v.)	组装, 装配	The company will assemble the final product in its local factory to reduce costs. (该公司将在其本地工厂 组装 最终产品以降低成本。)
12	sort out (v.)	整理, 理清	It took the new manager a week to sort out the chaotic filing system. (新经理花了一周时间才 理清 了混乱的档案系统。)
13	condense into	压缩成, 简化	The complex research findings were condensed

	(v.)	为	into a brief executive summary. (复杂的研究发现被 压缩成 一份简短的管理层摘要。)
14	inhalation (n.)	吸气	Proper inhalation technique is crucial for the effective administration of some asthma medications. (正确的 吸气 技巧对于某些哮喘药物的有效施用至关重要。)
15	exhalation (n.)	呼气	The doctor asked the patient to complete a full exhalation before taking the X-ray. (医生要求患者在拍 X 光前完成一次完整的 呼气 。)
16	prolonged (adj.)	延长的, 持久的	Prolonged exposure to air pollution has been linked to chronic respiratory diseases. (长期的 空气污染暴露与慢性呼吸道疾病有关。)
17	muscle tone (n.)	肌肉张力	Physical therapy can help improve muscle tone and coordination in patients after a stroke. (物理治疗有助于改善中风后患者的 肌肉张力 和协调性。)
18	posture (n.)	姿势	Ergonomic chairs are designed to support a healthy sitting posture and reduce back pain. (符合人体工学的椅子旨在支撑健康的 坐姿 并减少背痛。)
19	sequence (n.)	顺序, 序列	Scientists have now mapped the entire genetic sequence of the organism. (科学家现已绘制出该生物体的完整基因 序列 。)
20	slice off (v.)	切下, 薄薄地切掉一层	The surgeon will slice off a thin layer of the damaged tissue. (外科医生将 切掉 一层受损的组织。)
21	cornea (n.)	角膜	The cornea is the transparent front part of the eye that covers the iris and pupil. (角膜 是眼睛透明的部分, 覆盖着虹膜和瞳孔。)
22	ultraviolet laser (n.)	紫外线激光	An ultraviolet laser is often used in eye surgery for its precision and ability to make clean cuts. (紫外线激光 因其精确性和能够进行干净切割的能力而常用于眼部手术。)
23	reaffix (v.)	重新贴上, 重新固定	After the inspection, the panel was carefully reaffixed to the machine. (检查结束后, 面板被小心地 重新安装 到机器上。)
24	eyewall (n.)	眼壁(气象学)	The most destructive winds in a hurricane are found within the eyewall . (飓风中最具破坏性的风出现在 眼壁 内。)
25	precipitation (n.)	降水	The level of precipitation directly impacts the region's agricultural output. (降水量 直接影响该地区的农业产出。)
26	rain band (n.)	雨带(气象学)	The outer rain bands of the storm can bring rainfall hundreds of kilometers from the center.

			(风暴的外围 雨带 能在距离中心数百公里外的地方带来降雨。)
27	culinary (adj.)	烹饪的	The city has become a culinary destination, attracting food enthusiasts from around the world. (这座城市已成为一个 烹饪胜地 , 吸引了世界各地的美食爱好者。)
28	air-traffic controller (n.)	空中交通管制员	The role of an air-traffic controller is critical for maintaining the safety and efficiency of the aviation system. (空中交通管制员 的角色对于维护航空系统的安全与效率至关重要。)
29	aviation (n.)	航空, 航空业	Sustainable aviation fuel is seen as a key to reducing the industry's carbon footprint. (可持续 航空 燃料被视为减少该行业碳足迹的关键。)
30	causal (adj.)	因果关系的, 原因的	Establishing a causal link between the two variables requires more than just correlation. (要确立这两个变量之间的 因果关系 , 仅有关联性是不够的。)
31	chronological (adj.)	按时间顺序的	The historian presented the events in chronological order to provide a clear narrative. (这位历史学家按 时间顺序 陈述事件, 以提供一个清晰的叙述。)
32	command (n.)	掌握, 精通	Her command of multiple languages was a great asset in the diplomatic corps. (她对多种语言的 掌握 在外交部门是一大财富。)
33	implication (n.)	含义, 暗示; 可能的影响	The research has profound implications for our understanding of early human migration. (这项研究对我们理解早期人类迁徙具有深远的 影响 。)
34	initiative (n.)	倡议; 主动性	The company launched a green initiative to reduce its plastic waste by 50%. (该公司发起了一项绿色 倡议 , 旨在减少 50% 的塑料废物。)
35	isolate (v.)	分离, 隔离; 单独考虑	It is difficult to isolate the effect of any single factor in a complex economic system. (在一个复杂的经济体系中, 很难 分离 出任何一个单一因素的影响。)
36	legislation (n.)	法律, 立法	New legislation was passed to regulate the use of artificial intelligence. (新的 法律 已获通过, 以规范人工智能的使用。)
37	versatile (adj.)	多功能的, 用途广泛的	Smartphones are versatile devices that have replaced numerous standalone products. (智能手机是 多功能 的设备, 取代了许多独立的产品。)
38	workable (adj.)	可行的, 行得通的	After days of negotiation, the two parties finally reached a workable compromise. (经过数日谈判, 双方最终达成了一个 可行 的妥协方案。)

Exercise

I Fill in each blank with the most appropriate word or phrase. Each word or phrase can be used only once.

congestion, sensor, expressly, prolonged, posture, sequence, precipitation, culinary, aviation, causal, chronological, initiative, isolate, legislation, versatile, workable

1. The new policy was _____ designed to encourage investment in renewable energy.
2. The city is implementing a new traffic management system to reduce chronic _____ during rush hours.
3. The _____ industry has been severely impacted by the global pandemic, leading to widespread travel restrictions.
4. Researchers are trying to _____ the specific gene responsible for the hereditary condition.
5. The new law provides a _____ framework for addressing the complex issue of digital asset ownership.
6. The chef has gained international fame for his innovative _____ techniques.
7. Historians have arranged the events in _____ order to provide a clear timeline of the empire's rise and fall.
8. The company is developing a highly _____ material that can be used in everything from construction to consumer electronics.

II Circle the most suitable choice to replace the underlined word or phrase.

9. The report provides the basic framework for our future research.
A. skeleton
B. congestion
C. sensor
D. posture
10. The evidence does not match the witness's testimony.
A. project from
B. correspond to
C. slice off
D. reaffix
11. The manager asked the team to compress the lengthy report **into** a one-page summary.
A. sort out
B. condense into
C. assemble into
D. combat into

12. The **implications** of this scientific discovery could be revolutionary.
- A. initiatives
 - B. precipitations
 - C. sequences
 - D. implications
13. The surgeon will **cut off** a thin layer of tissue to access the affected area.
- A. reassemble
 - B. slice off
 - C. sort out
 - D. condense into
14. Her **mastery** of three foreign languages impressed the interview panel.
- A. posture
 - B. inhalation
 - C. command
 - D. legislation
15. The **relationship between cause and effect** between the two phenomena is still being debated.
- A. causal link
 - B. chronological order
 - C. muscle tone
 - D. science fiction
16. After the calibration, the technician had to **reattach** the protective cover.
- A. slice off
 - B. reaffix
 - C. assemble
 - D. project from

III Translation: Chinese to English

1. 组织演讲主体的过程始于确定要点，这些要点构成了演讲的**骨架**，需要被精心选择、**准确措辞**并**策略性地**排列。
2. 如果发现要点过多，你可以将它们**归纳到更宽泛**的类别中。例如，可以将关于瑜伽呼吸法和体式的多个要点**筛选出来**，**相应地**归入两个主要类别。
3. 因果顺序的组织结构是**灵活多变的**。你可以将第一个要点**专门用于**阐述原因，第二个要点用于阐述结果，**反之亦然**。